MSc. Social Protection. Hochschule Bonn Rhein Sieg. Module 8. Social Protection Reforms.
Student: Pablo Herrera.
Prof. Dr. Derya Gür-Şeker, Prof. Dr. Matthias Meißner, Prof. Dr. Krzysztof Hagemejer.

Reform Proposal:

Extension of pre-primary coverage school attendance in Chile.

Introduction

Early childhood education can have valuable and lasting positive impacts on development. In Chile, the mandatory level, from 5 years old, presents a coverage higher than 90%. However, under that level, the attendance is lower. This is also more problematic for lower income households, and for rural areas.

Studies also show less female participation in the labour market for women that take care duties responsibilities. Chilean female labour market presents both, lower participation and higher informality when compared with men.

The following sections of this memorandum aim to: study the lack of attendance and identify key populations with lower coverage, then proposes an action plan to implement a gradual increase of the attendance to care and educational establishments, among early age children. A legal and political analysis as well as cost projections are part of this document.

Background

In Chile, pre-primary education is mandatory only for the last year before primary education (known in Chile as Transition 2 or Kinder). Until 4 years old is not. The Chilean State provides it but reaches a lower coverage than at the mandatory levels (Chile, 2009; Political Constitution of the Republic of Chile).

As part of the Sustainable Development Goals, it can be said that the fourth goal cares about the promotion of early childhood development, and also states the relevance of the current mandatory level in Chile (from the 5 years old) (United Nations, 2022).

In France, as a comparison, during the 1960s and 70s a large expansion took place. Leading the country to an increase of the enrolment rate. By the beginning of the 70s, the country reached more than 90% for 3 and 4 years old. A 2010 study found short- and long-term effects of this in both educational and labour market outcomes (Dumas and Lefranc, 2010).

Back to Latin America, studies show positive relations between provision of early childhood education and care (ECEC) and higher female labour market participation in the continent (Filgueira & Martínez Franzoni, 2019; Amarante, Rossel & Scalese, 2024).

Objectives

This reform proposal aims to expand the coverage of Chilean pre-primary education services. This through both a better planning of the public supply in order to cover the existing gaps but also campaigns among parents and tutors to increase awareness of the relevance of pre-primary education and thus, promote children participation.

As final goal, this proposed reform attempts both, to improve the development of early age children and to increase the chances for female labour market participation.

Motivation/justification

Data from the Chilean Social Characterization Survey (Casen) allows a coverage analysis for this proposal. In the year 2022, less than 6 % of 5 years old children, were not attending to educational institutions. When focusing on children within 2 and 4 years old, the national non-attendance average is 42.1%. From a total of 774.387 children in these age grouups, 326.148 do not attend (Table 1).

Separating by age, the non-attendance rates are: 61,3% for 2 years old children, 45.7% for 3 years old and 22.8% for 4 years old (Figure 1). The main reason for this was that the parents considered that it was no needed (Figure 2). The analysis by sex, displays that non-attending girls reach 42.9%, 1.6 percentage points more than boys (41.3%).

If the analysis is done by income deciles, the poorest 40% of the population presents a non-attendance percentage higher than the national average (41.7%) (Figure 3). Of a total of 326.148 children who do not attend educational institutions, 198.989 are in the four lowest

income deciles. Addressing the gap for the most vulnerable 40% of the population, solves the 60% of the national non-attendance rate.

Comparing by rural and urban areas, more than half of the children in rural areas (55.5%) don't attend to educational institutions, while this percentage reaches 40.6% in urban areas (urban areas outperform almost 15 percentage points better than rural areas).

An analysis of attendance by region and area (urban and rural), allows the creation of four categories of regions (Table 2, see also Figures 4 and 5 for a visual inspection of the non-attendance rates).

- Priority regions: three regions that are above the national non-attendance average.
- Rural priority regions: five regions that are above the national average only in rural areas.
- Urban priority regions: two regions that are above the national average only in urban areas.
- Non-priority regions: six regions are under the national average of non-attendance in both areas.

Besides the impact that early participation of children in the educational system can bring to their future outcomes, widening the coverage can also motivate the female labour participation (Castro and Da Cruz, 2024).

Data from the Chilean National Statistics Institute (INE) show consistently a higher rate of informality for women, than for men (Figure 6). In the case of the unemployment rates, women are also in a worse position than men (Figure 7). This policy could benefit not only children as the target group, but also women involved in their care.

Legal strategy

The legal context surrounding this reform is quite clear in Chile. Various legal bodies refer to care and early childhood education, supporting both the relevance of these matters in the country, but also its compatibility with the proposed reform. This begins with the political constitution, passing through more specific laws ruling the educational sector, the different public institutions involved and the regulation of the provision of pre-school services itself.

At the international level, Chile has subscribed to agreements such as the Universal Declaration of Human Rights and the Convention on the Rights of the Child. Both of them from the United Nations, which also refer to the relevance of early childhood and education related policies, being clear about the minimum standards that the state must offer.

However, at the operative level the law is more fragmented. This has allowed lack of coordination and disbalances on the allocation of public resources.

A. National and international legal bodies.

On the national level, the constitution states the right to education, which also refers to the duty of the state regarding the promotion and provision of early childhood education for free from the 2 years old, and in a mandatory basis from the 5 years old. Additionally, during the last attempt at constitutional reform in Chile, it was set that the proposed constitution should follow a certain structure. This included the guarantee of freedom of education, as well as the preferential right and duty of families to choose their children's education (Political Constitution of the Republic of Chile).

Additionally, the law has complementary regulations, like the General Education Law, indicating how early childhood education should operate and that it is not a mandatory requirement for school entry. It also establishes its objectives, such as fostering the comprehensive development of children and promoting the learning, knowledge, skills, and attitudes that enable their development and expression (Chile, 2005).

Finally other legal bodies set the structure and responsibilities of relevant institutions like the Undersecretariat of Early Childhood Education (Chile, 2016), part of the Ministry of Education, or the National Board of Kindergartens (JUNJI by its acronym in Spanish) (Chile, 2025).

On the international stage, the mentioned Universal Declaration of Human Rights (United Nations, 1948) and the Convention on the Rights of the Child (United Nations, 1989). The first one recognizes the right of mothers and children to receive special care and assistance. But also, it recognizes that parents have the prior right on choosing the education that children should receive, the same way the Chilean constitution does.

In the case of the Convention on the Rights of the Child, of which Chile is a signatory state, this matter is also addressed. The agreement states that establishments dedicated to the care or protection of children must comply with the guidelines of competent authorities. Other articles also declare that the child's right to education must be recognized under conditions of equal opportunity. Regarding objectives, the system is intended to develop the child's personality, as well as their mental and physical abilities, to the maximum extent possible.

One of the main takes aways from both, the local and international legal frameworks, is that this reform, focused on expanding coverage, is completely compatible with them. While the target population of this reform is under the mandatory level, it is still provided by the government when demanded.

B. Weaknesses.

Although the general regulations sound well, in practice there is still a fragmented ecosystem that lacks coordination. One of the problems of this, is the inequality in terms of resources among different providers of early childhood education. The public provision can be funded through different legal bodies. One option is the JUNJI by direct administration, another one is the Integra Foundation which is a private non-profit institution that provides public preschool education funded by the Ministry of Education.

The third alternative is when local governments administer the establishments and receive funds transferred through the JUNJI according to the children attendance. This third alternative covers the largest number of children registered but receives the lowest funding per child (Ciper, 2024; Observatorio Niñez, 2024).

The fact that these different systems aim to cover the same target population, i.e. minors belonging to the 60% of the most disadvantaged families in the country, makes the existence of the imbalances mentioned, more counterintuitive.

A reform that aims to extend the coverage of the early education services, should also look into a system that offers a more standardized service in terms of the resources available, no matter through which channel the families are accessing to public education.

Time frame

As part of the motivation, it was mentioned that the first four income deciles account for 60% of children who do not attend to educational institutions. This reform aims to address only that level of income. It was also mentioned that rural areas lag behind urban areas. Furthermore, the regional analysis has led to the creation of four groups of regions for this proposal (Table 2).

Considering this background, a gradual implementation plan is proposed. The goal behind this phased implementation is to avoid overloading the educational system and ensure that the learnings from the early stages can be taken into account in the following phases. The plan starts in 2027 with the rural areas of the regions from Group 1. After two years, the Group 1 would be completed covering also the urban areas. A third and a fourth stage would include the rural areas of Group 2 and the urban areas of Group 3. A final stage would cover the remaining areas (see Figure 8 for a detailed Gantt Chart).

Analysis of costs

For reference, Chilean expenditure on public early childhood and care services have been stable around 0,5% of GDP over the years according to OECD (a) data.

It should also be noted that the population of the country is ageing, with a decrease in the number of children in absolute terms (United Nations, 2024).

For the projection of the costs that this reform implies, some considerations about the objective population are relevant. This reform aims to address only children between 2 and 4 years old, that are also part of the poorest 40% of the population. The amount of people covered per year is based on the gradual implementation plan presented in the Time Frame section.

The projection of the population made until 2050 is constructed as follows: the starting point are the non-attending children based on the Chilean Social Characterization Survey (Casen) 2022. From this year and until 2050, a growth rate is applied to this starting point. This rate is calculated based on the 2- to 4-year-old population growth projected by the UN. Three different projections are used: medium variant, high variant and low variant.

About the costs, the annual cost of a pre-primary provision per child is available on a Ministry of Education of Chile (2020) document (around 2.900.000 CLP, which was almost 4.000 USD). The amount is adjusted by inflation to 2024 levels (National Institute of Statistics of Chile). From 2025, an annual inflation rate of 4% is assumed.

Finally, about the GDP, the starting point is the 2024 data, available at the Statistical Database from the Central Bank of Chile. From 2025, is assumed a growth rate of 5%.

As it can be seen in the Figure 9, as the stages of the project progress, the projected costs do so. After reaching the last group in 2033, the medium variant projection reaches about 0.35% of the GDP. After this, the decrease of the population in the target age groups leads to a decrease in the total costs of covering the target population.

Sources of funding

When it comes to the sources of funding, in the case of a reform of proposal with permanent expenditures, the source should come from permanent incomes. While the fiscal trajectory of Chile is strong, during the last 10 years the country has been mainly a net borrower with controlled numbers between -7.5 and 1.4 (International Monetary Fund).

The average tax burden of OECD countries on GDP is 33.4% for 2019, which for Chile is 20.9%. The main sources of collection between the countries OECD are contributions to social security, the income tax of the people and the value added tax. In the case of Chile, its sources of income are organized different with the contributions to Social Security and the Income Tax of People, being lower than OECD average (7.3 and 7.2% in Chile, against 25.9 and 23.5% at the OECD average), but with a higher VAT 20.3% at the OECD level) (Cabrera, 2022).

In the last years, the Chilean politicians have been discussing about implementing a tax reform. During 2022 a proposal from the Budget Ministry projected that with its implementation, the Chilean government could collect about 4% of the GDP (Ministerio de Hacienda, 2022), which would be around 12 times the resources needed for this extension of the attendance to early childhood education.

Thus, the resources needed for this reform could be funded with some of the extra state revenue provided from an eventual tax reform. This allows the country to deal with permanent expenses with what should be a permanent source of resources.

Barriers to overcome

As any policy that aims to increase the public expenditure this proposal may face opposition from sectors that would prioritize other areas. While international evidence shows that investing in early childhood generates returns, a proposal to increase spending on early childhood education by 0.5% of GDP may face resistance.

Since this is an increase in public spending in a context where total spending already reaches 24.6% of GDP (World Bank, 2023), some sectors could argue that fiscal space is limited and that there are other urgent priorities, such as health (accounting for 10.1% of GDP) (World Bank) or social security, which absorbs an important share of resources (12.9% of GDP in social spending) (OECD b).

While early childhood education can have a better position to be accepted within the political debate, political disagreement can still exist between government and opposition parties which can give relevance to different elements of the implementation. For instance, during 2024 the parliament was dealing with the discussion of reforms related to this issues, and while both sectors wanted to strengthen the public provision of early childhood education, one of them was against it stating that the discussed project was more focused on providing day care services rather than on early age education (Ex-Ante, 2024). During this discussions also, there has been disagreement on the amount needed to improve the services (ADN Radio, 2025).

Finally, as has been mentioned in previous sections of this document, both international and local legal bodies highlight the freedom of the parents to choose their children's education. Bringing thus the problem that parents would be interested in use the public resources in another kind of institution.

Alternative reform's designs

If the proposed reform needs to be adjusted in order to be successful in both the public opinion and the political debate, there are different decisions that can be made to modify the current proposal.

A possible path with different options to adjust is changing the focalization of the project. The reform could focus only in children from 3 to 4 years old, since the existing gaps are not as big as they are for 2 year old children. Changing the income level can be another option, for example to address a higher rate of the non-attending population.

In terms of the implementation plan, it can also be discussed if the priorities should include urban areas, or a rearrangement of the implementation plan could be done, focusing in rural areas only. Regarding the implementation plan, the graduality can also be adjusted, making some stages longer in order to reduce the expenditures and also to have more time to adjust it.

Finally, an alternative could also be to strength the reform including targeted benefits for mothers and female tutors that could be particularly benefited by early childhood education services, in order to take part in the labour market. This could consider for instance, mentoring programs for reintegration in the world of work.

Recommendations

The main recommendations for the implementation of this reform could be connected to both previous sections: Barriers to overcome and the Alternative reform's designs.

From the design of the policy, the main recommendation is maintain the gradual implementation, which could facilitate the reform's sustainability. However, the priority population could be discussed (changing the income level, the children’s age groups and the discussion between rural and urban areas.

Since the disagreement about how to implement this reform and also what to prioritize, promoting the discussion between different political sectors and also the civil society organizations can give more validity to the reform, and thus help to avoid difficulties in discussion in parliament once the proposal is already written.

Conclusions

Chile has both a national legal framework and international commitments that support the expansion of early childhood education coverage. The Constitution, the General Education Law, and agreements such as the Convention on the Rights of the Child provide a clear basis for the proposal, showing its consistency with existing obligations.

In fiscal terms, the projected costs of the reform reach about 0.35% of GDP by 2033. While this is a moderate level of expenditure, it must be considered in the context of total public spending, which already accounts for 24.6% of GDP. Limited fiscal space and competing priorities can generate resistance. Political disagreements may also arise regarding the way this expansion of the coverage should be accomplished.

Institutional fragmentation represents another challenge. The coexistence of separated institutions in the provision results in non-standardized funding and lack of coordination. Without greater integration, expanding coverage risks reinforcing existing disparities in service provision.

Nevertheless, the expected benefits are considerable. Expanding access to early childhood education would strengthen child development, promote greater equity, and support female labour market participation. These outcomes position the reform as an investment in human capital with broad social returns. The proposed gradual and targeted implementation enhances both its financial sustainability and political viability.

Ultimately, success will depend on building political consensus, incorporating civil society, and ensuring mechanisms that guarantee quality and equity. If these conditions are met, the reform can transcend the fiscal debate and become a transformative policy for Chile’s early childhood development.

Literature

- ADN Radio (June 24th, 2025). Parlamentarios cuestionan financiamiento de nueva sala cuna universal: acusan que aporte del Gobierno es insuficiente. Parliamentarians question funding for new universal daycare: they accuse the government of insufficient funding. Availableat: https://www.adnradio.cl/2025/06/24/parlamentarios-cuestionan-financiamiento-de-nueva-sala-cuna-universal-acusan-que-aporte-del-gobierno-es-insuficiente/
- Amarante, V., Rossel, C., & Scalese, F. (2024). Hours of Work and Early Childhood Education and Access to Care Services in Latin America: Evidence From Colombia, Chile, Mexico, and Uruguay. Journal of Family Issues, 45(8), 1867–1896. https://doi.org/10.1177/0192513x231194296
- Cabrera, F. (2022). Reforma tributaria 2022. Impuestos de segunda categoría en los países de la OCDE. Available at: https://obtienearchivo.bcn.cl/obtienearchivo?id=repositorio/10221/33705/1/OECD_RT_Impuestos_segunda_categori__a_RT2022_FINAL.pdf
- Castro, M., & Da Cruz, B. (2024). Effects of a large-scale program for the construction of daycare and preschool centers on cognitive skills and female employment. Education Economics, 32(6), 786–811. https://doi.org/10.1080/09645292.2023.2254516
- Central Bank of Chile. Base de Datos Estadísticos (BDE). [Statistical Database]. Available at: https://si3.bcentral.cl/Siete/ES/Siete/Cuadro/CAP_CCNN/MN_CCNN76/CCNN2018_P0_V2/637801082315858005?cbFechaInicio=2013&cbFechaTermino=2025&cbFrecuencia=ANNUAL&cbCalculo=NONE&cbFechaBase=
- Chile. (2009). Decreto con Fuerza de Ley N° 2: Fija texto refundido, coordinado y sistematizado de la Ley General de Educación (LGE) [Decree with Force of Law No. 2: Consolidated, Coordinated, and Systematized Text of the General Education Law]. Diario Oficial de la República de Chile. https://www.bcn.cl/leychile/navegar?idNorma=1014974
- Chile (2016). Ley N.º 20.835: Crea la Subsecretaría de Educación Parvularia, la Intendencia de Educación Parvularia y modifica diversos cuerpos legales [Law No.

20,835: Creates the Undersecretariat for Early Childhood Education, the Superintendence of Early Childhood Education, and Amends Various Legal Bodies]. Diario Oficial de la República de Chile. https://www.bcn.cl/leychile/navegar?idNorma=1077041

- Chile (2025). Ley N.º 17.301: Crea corporación denominada Junta Nacional de Jardines Infantiles (JUNJI) [Law No. 17,301: Creates the Corporation Called National Board of Kindergartens (JUNJI)]. Diario Oficial de la República de Chile. https://www.bcn.cl/leychile/navegar?idNorma=28904
- Ciper (2024). Educación parvularia: Institucionalidad y financiamiento. Available at: http://ciperchile.cl/2024/01/25/educacion-parvularia-institucionalidad-y-financiamiento/
- Dumas, C., & Lefranc, A. (2010). Early schooling and later outcomes: Evidence from pre-school extension in France. From parents to children: the intergenerational transmission of advantage, Russel Sage Foundation. Available at: https://ideas.repec.org/p/ema/worpap/2010-07.html
- Ex-Ante (April 2nd, 2024). Rebelión oficialista contra ministra Orellana: Senado aprueba sala cuna universal solo con votos de oposición. [Official rebellion against Minister Orellana: Senate approves universal nursery with only opposition votes]. Available at: https://www.ex-ante.cl/rebelion-oficialista-contra-ministra-orellana-senado-aprueba-sala-cuna-universal-solo-con-votos-de-oposicion/
- Filgueira, F., & Martínez Franzoni, J. (2019). Growth to Limits of Female Labor Participation in Latin America's Unequal Care Regime1. Social Politics: International Studies in Gender, State & Society, 26(2), 245–275. https://doi.org/10.1093/sp/jxz015
- International Monetary Fund. World Economic Outlook Database. Available at: https://www.imf.org/en/Publications/WEO/weo-database/2025/april
- Ministry of Education Chile (2020). Evaluación de Programas Gubernamentales: Programa de Jardines Infantiles y Salas Cunas convencionales de Integra. [Evaluation of Government Programs: Integra's Conventional Kindergarten and Nursery Program]. Available at: https://www.dipres.gob.cl/597/articles-205701_informe_final.pdf

- Ministerio de Hacienda (2022). Reforma Tributaria: Hacia un pacto fiscal por el desarrollo y la justicia social. Available at: https://www.hacienda.cl/noticias-y-eventos/documentos-reforma-tributaria/minuta-sobre-contenido-del-proyecto-de-reforma-tributaria
- National Institute of Statistics of Chile. Calculadora para el Indice de Precios al Consumidor. [Consumer Price Index calculator]. Available at: https://calculadoraipc.ine.cl/
- Observatorio Niñez (2024). Radiografía de la educación parvularia en Chile. Available at: https://www.observatorioninez.org/mapa/radiografia-de-la-educacion-parvularia-en-chile?
- OECD a. Public expenditure on family by type of expenditure (cash and in kind) in % GDP. Available at: https://data-explorer.oecd.org/vis?tm=family&pg=0&snb=148&df[ds]=dsDisseminateFinalDMZ&df[id]=DSD_SOCX_AGG%40DF_PUB_FAM&df[ag]=OECD.ELS.SPD&df[vs]=1.0&dq=CHL.A..PT_B1GQ..C%2BK..&pd=2010%2C&to[TIME_PERIOD]=false&vw=tb
- OECD b. Data, Trusted statistics supporting evidence-based policy. Available at: https://www.oecd.org/en/data/indicators.html?orderBy=mostRelevant&page=0
- Political Constitution of the Republic of Chile. Available at: https://www.camara.cl/camara/doc/leyes_normas/constitucion.pdf
- United Nations. (1948). Universal Declaration of Human Rights. Available at: https://www.un.org/en/about-us/universal-declaration-of-human-rights
- United Nations. (1989). Convention on the Rights of the Child. Available at: https://www.ohchr.org/en/instruments-mechanisms/instruments/convention-rights-child
- United Nations (2022). Global indicator framework for the Sustainable Development Goals and targets of the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development. Available at: https://unstats.un.org/sdgs/indicators/Global%20Indicator%20Framework%20after%202022%20refinement_Eng.pdf

- United Nations (2024). World Population Prospects 2024. Available at: https://www.observatorioninez.org/mapa/radiografia-de-la-educacion-parvularia-en-chile?
- World Bank. World Bank Open Data. Available at https://data.worldbank.org/

Annex

Table 1. Percentage of attendance to educational institutions, for children between 2 and 4 years old.

	Total	%
Attending	448.239	57,9
Not attending	326.148	42,1
All children	774.387	100,0

Figure 1. Evolution non-attendance to educational establishments rate over time, by age.

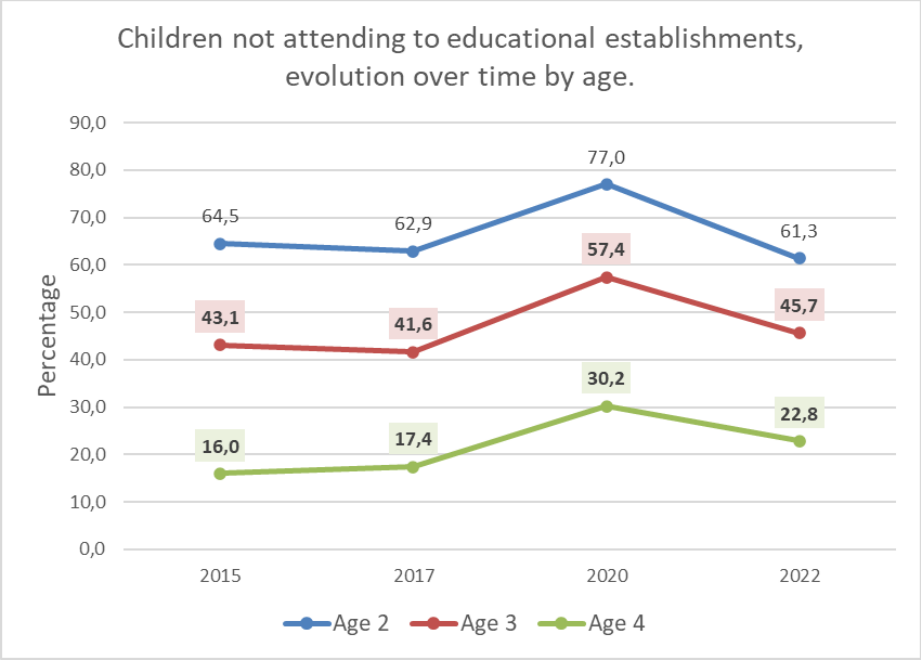


Figure 2. Reasons for non-attendance to educational establishments, by age (2022).

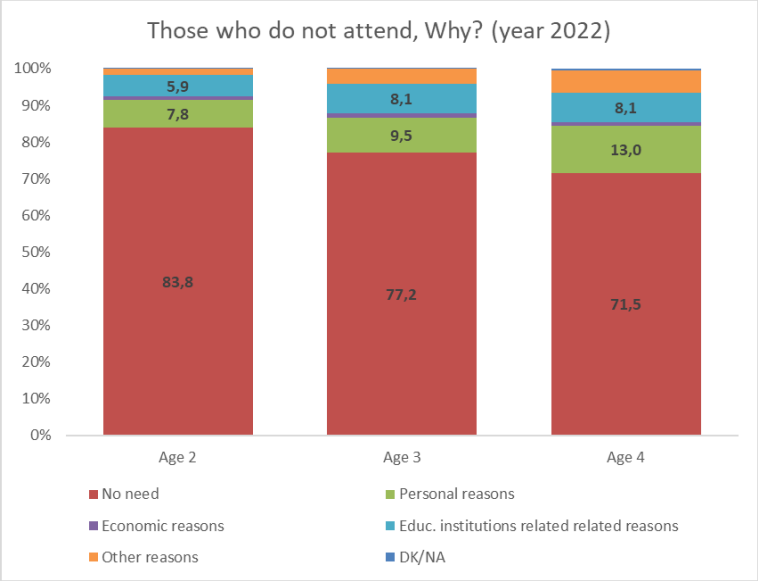


Figure 3. Non attendance to educational establishments for selected age group by decile.

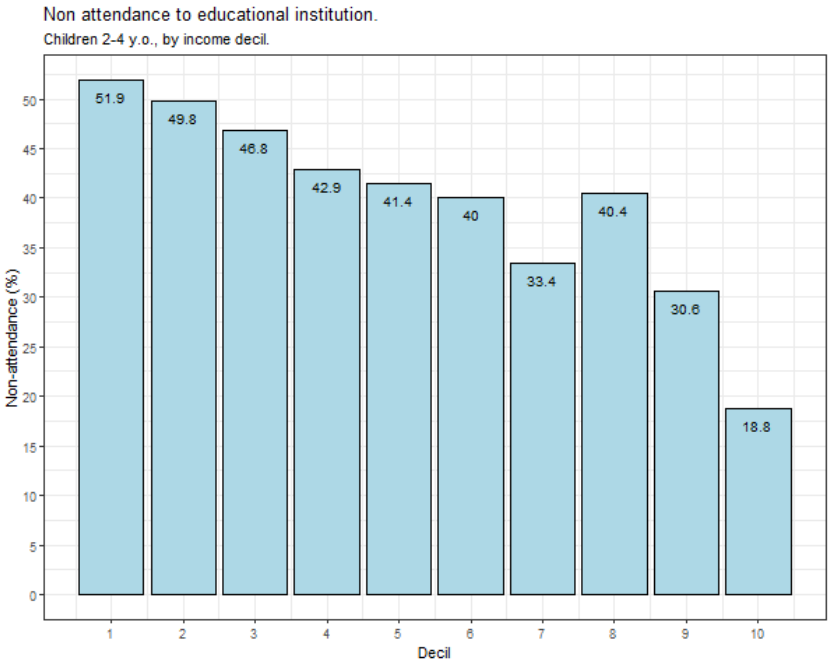


Figure 4. Non-attendance to educational institutions in rural areas, by region.

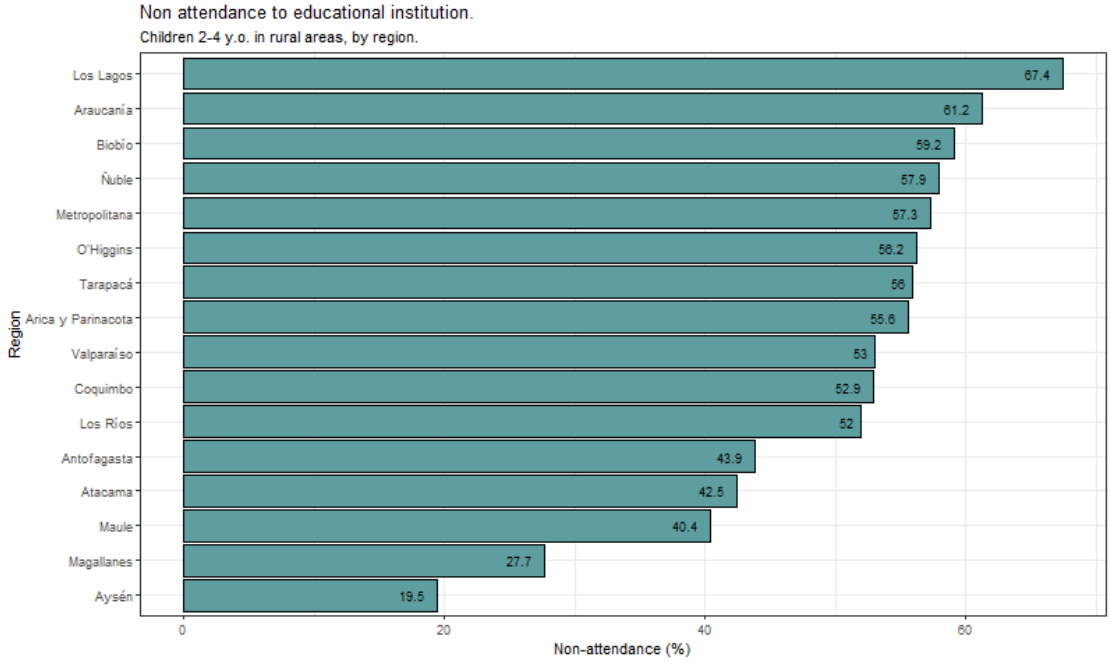


Figure 5. Non-attendance to educational institutions in urban areas, by region.

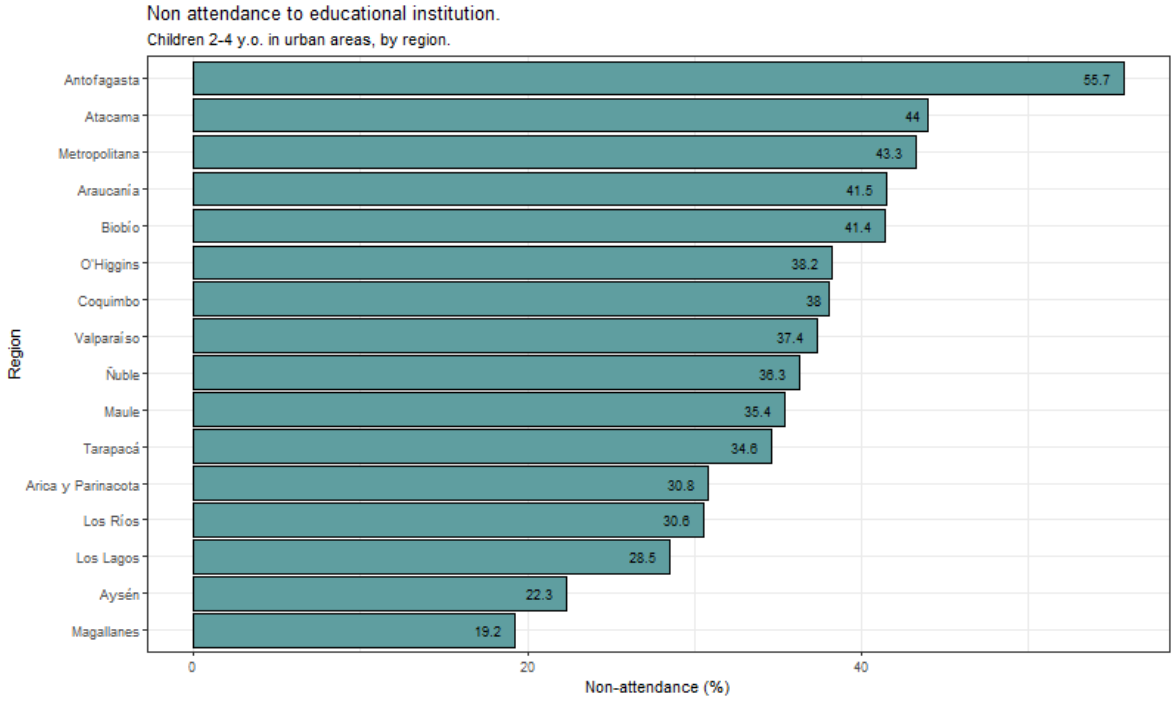


Table 2. Non-attendance amount of children and percentages, by region and area. Regions sorted by 4 suggested groups.

Name region	Total children (2-4 y.o.)	N non attending	% of region	N non attending (urban)	% of region (urban)	N non attending (rural)	% of region (rural)
Biobío	63.359	27.327	43,1	23.619	41,4	3.708	59,2
Araucanía	40.703	19.153	47,1	12.109	41,5	7.044	61,2
Metropolitana	327.160	143.083	43,7	136.778	43,3	6.305	57,3
Tarapacá	19.963	7.181	36,0	6.462	34,6	719	56,0
O'Higgins	39.624	16.752	42,3	11.712	38,2	5.040	56,2
Los Lagos	34.018	12.559	36,9	7.618	28,5	4.941	67,4
Arica y Parinacota	10.553	3.616	34,3	2.791	30,8	825	55,6
Ñuble	18.620	8.123	43,6	4.481	36,3	3.642	57,9
Antofagasta	30.982	17.161	55,4	16.829	55,7	332	43,9
Atacama	12.848	5.639	43,9	5.345	44,0	294	42,5
Coquimbo	30.123	12.148	40,3	9.684	38,0	2.464	52,9
Valparaíso	77.554	29.906	38,6	26.753	37,4	3.153	53,0
Maule	42.515	15.606	36,7	11.216	35,4	4.390	40,4
Aysén	4.191	920	22,0	810	22,3	110	19,5
Magallanes	7.132	1.416	19,9	1.273	19,2	143	27,7
Los Ríos	15.042	5.558	36,9	3.227	30,6	2.331	52,0
Total	**774.387**	**326.148**		**280.707**		**45.441**	

Figure 6. Labour market informality rate over time, by sex.

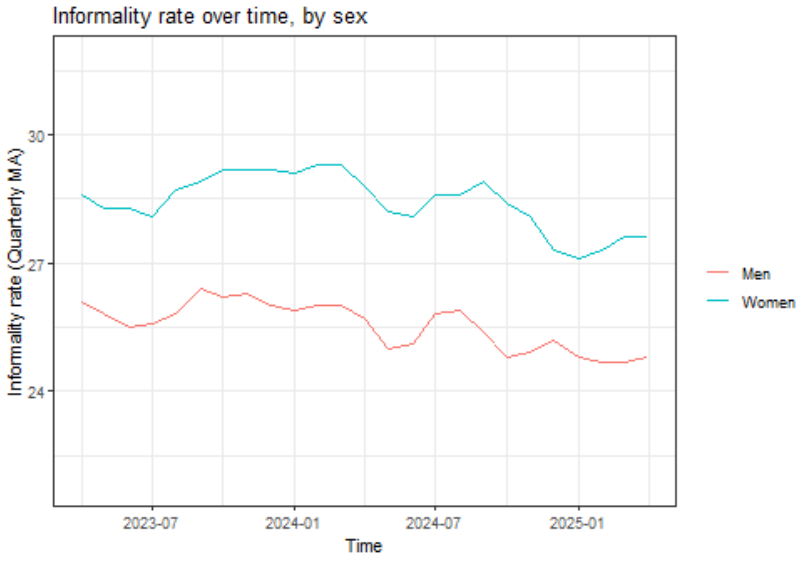


Figure 7. Labour market unemployment rate over time, by sex.

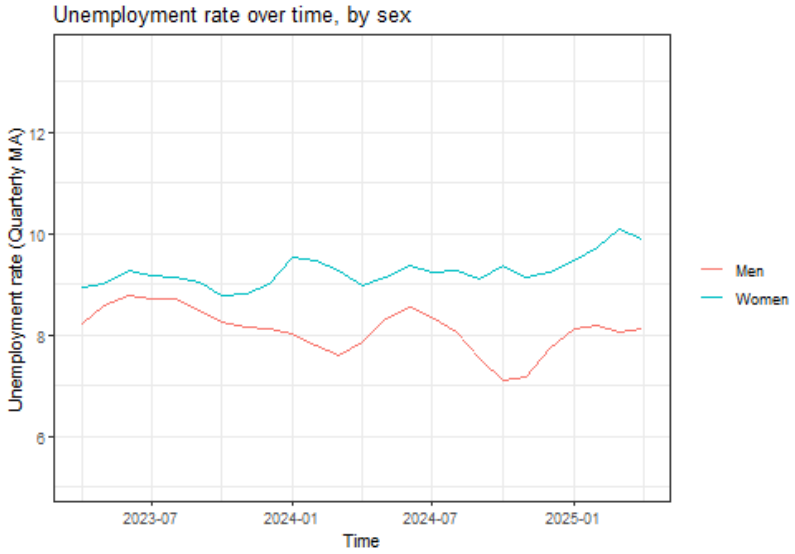


Figure 8. Gantt chart for the implementation of the reform (areas covered on each year).

		2027 - 28	2029 - 30	2031	2032	2033 - 50
Group 1	Rural areas	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
	Urban areas		✓	✓	✓	✓
Group 2	Rural areas			✓	✓	✓
	Urban areas					✓
Group 3	Rural areas					✓
	Urban areas				✓	✓
Group 4	Rural areas					✓
	Urban areas					✓
Progress		3%	29%	31%	35%	100%

Figure 9. Costs projection of the proposed reform over time as a percentage of GDP. Three scenarios considered based on high, medium and low variant population UN projections.

